

FULL REPORT • APRIL 2026

Seattle has one of America's best park systems. For dogs, *it's one of the worst.*

A public data reference on Seattle's off-leash dog area system: supply, access, enforcement, budget, peer cities, and one clearly-marked policy recommendation. Every number links back to a primary source.

WITHIN A 10-MIN
WALK OF AN OLA

11.7%

Seattle residents.
99% are within a 10-min walk of any park.

YEARS SINCE LAST
NEW OLA

17

Blue Dog Pond
(2009) → W. Seattle
Stadium (fall 2026).

FEWER OLAS PER
CAPITA THAN
PORTLAND

3.2×

Seattle 1.82 vs
Portland 5.74 per
100K (TPL 2025).

CITATIONS OUTSIDE
AN OLA WALKSHED

69.6%

2,035 of 2,925 park-named citations,
2014–2019 (PRR).

By Andre Vrignaud • Queen Anne, Seattle • seattledogparkdata.com • Source code + data: github.com/avrignaud/seattledogparkdata • MIT license.

Contents.

I	The Gap — Seattle added zero net OLAs in seventeen years
II	Access — the walkability paradox, acreage, and illegal off-leash use
III	Forward — what works, shared-use models, non-SPR land
IV	Enforcement — where the 4,803 citations happened
V	Budget — SPR total vs. the off-leash share of it
VI	Peer Cities — how eight cities run their systems
VII	Opinion & Recommendation — signed editorial
—	Methodology, sources, corrections, license

Parts I through VI are a public data reference. Part VII is clearly marked as opinion. Every factual claim links back to its primary source; the full site at seattledogparkdata.com is the canonical version.

PART I • THE GAP

Seattle added *zero* net off-leash areas in seventeen years.

The city's population grew by roughly 208,000 between 2010 and 2025. Its parks budget rose 37% on an apples-to-apples baseline. Two new off-leash areas open in late 2026 — the first net increase since 2009.

OLAS IN 2010

14

Total Seattle off-leash areas.

OLAS IN 2025

14

Unchanged. W. Seattle Stadium + Othello open late 2026.

POPULATION, 2010→2025

+34%

608,660 → 816,600 residents.

SPR BUDGET, 2019→2025

+37%

\$247.7M → \$339.4M all funds (apples-to-apples baseline).

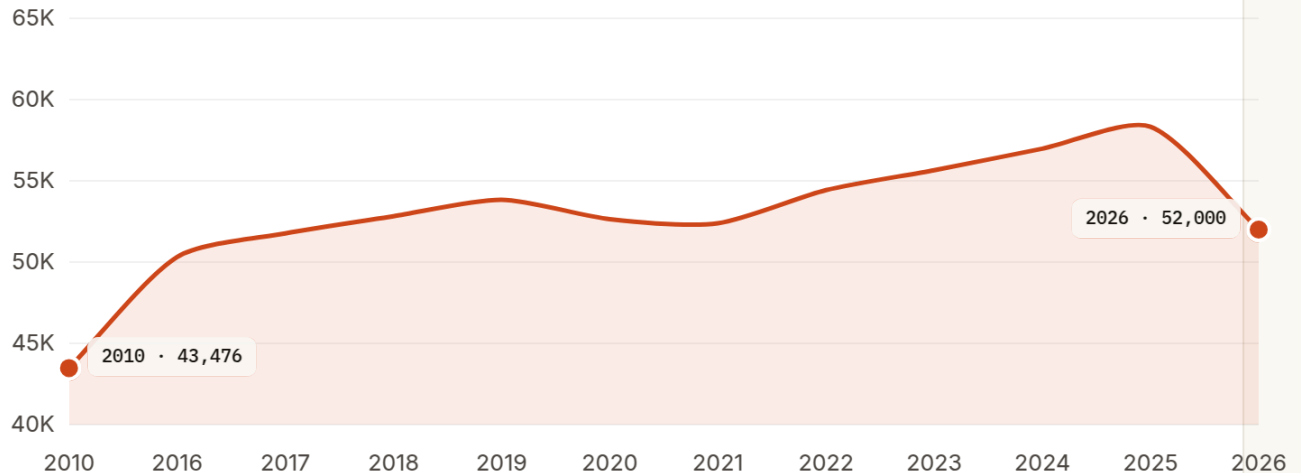
FINDING 01

Residents per off-leash area, over time.

Dividing Seattle's population by the number of OLAs: in 2010, one OLA served about 43,500 residents. In 2025 the figure is 58,329 — a 34% increase while the OLA count held at 14.

Residents per OLA, 2010–2026

The last OLAs opened in 2009. West Seattle Stadium and Othello Playground are scheduled to open fall 2026.



Source: WA OFM April 1 population estimates · SPR OLA inventory · Seattle Park District Cycle 2 Fact Sheet · [data/seattle-timeseries.csv](#)

OBSERVATION

With the two 2026 openings factored in, residents-per-OLA projects to ~52,000 — still above the 2010 figure of 43,476. Returning to the 2010 ratio at Seattle’s projected 2026 population (~832,000) would require 19 OLAs total, three more than the 16 projected for fall 2026.

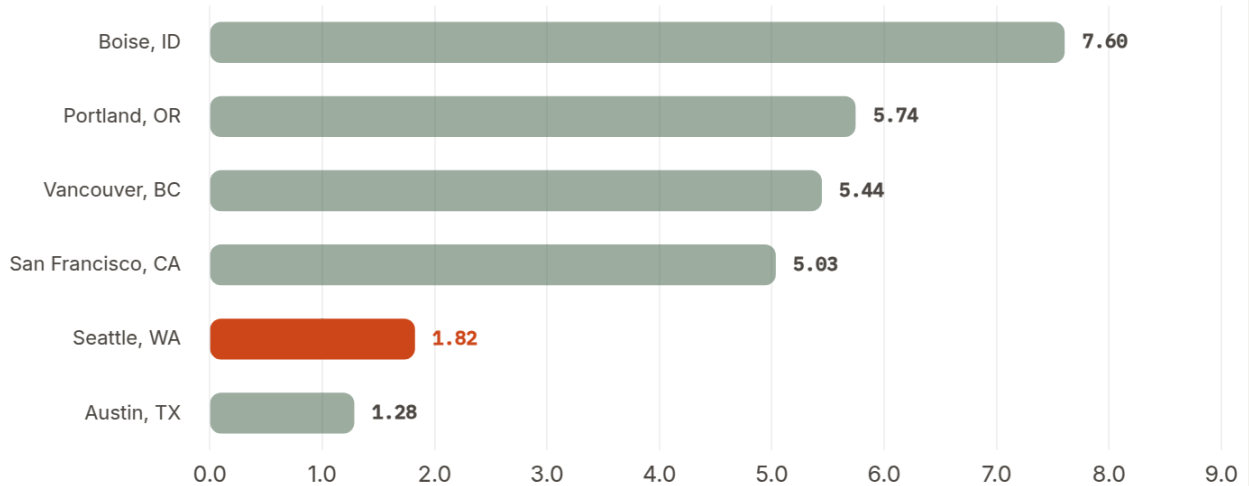
FINDING 02

The peer-city comparison.

Trust for Public Land's 2025 ParkScore measures dog parks per 100,000 residents. Seattle sits below every major West Coast peer; Portland is at roughly 3.2× Seattle's per-capita supply.

Dog parks per 100,000 residents, 2025

Comparable and aspirational cities. Vancouver BC uses self-reported count (36 OLAs) from the People, Parks & Dogs Strategy.



Source: TPL 2025 ParkScore Index · Vancouver Park Board People, Parks & Dogs Strategy (2017) · data/peer-cities.csv

OBSERVATION

Seattle's West Coast peers cluster near 5 dog parks per 100,000 residents; Seattle is at 1.82, adjacent to Austin (1.28). Boise (7.6) has led TPL's dog-park-per-capita category in recent years. Counting rules differ across cities — Portland counts some unfenced voice-control areas, Vancouver BC includes time-restricted shared-use — but normalizing for those differences narrows the gap without closing it.

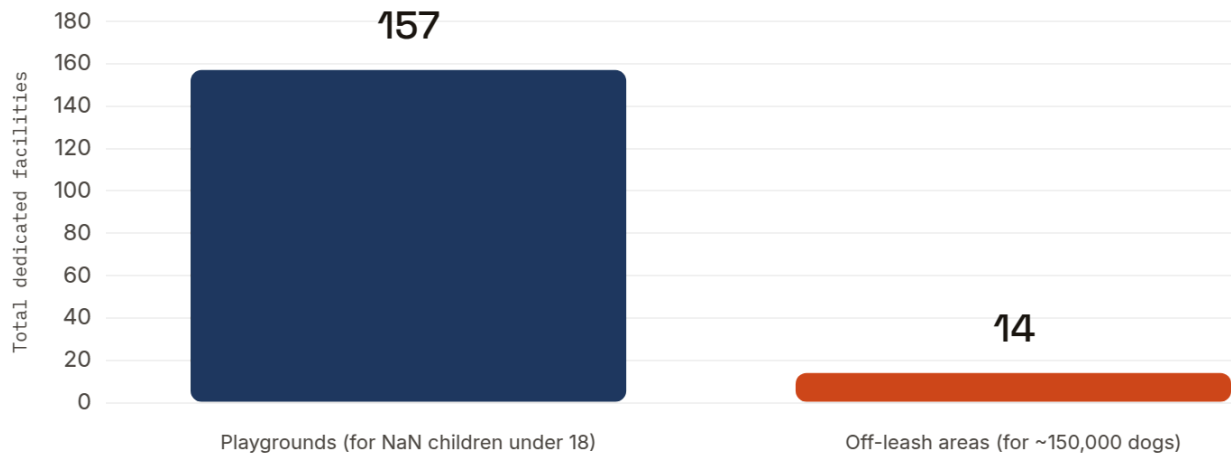
FINDING 03

Dedicated facilities: playgrounds vs. OLAs.

Seattle has 157 playgrounds for its under-18 population, and 14 OLAs for its dog population. Dog-population estimates range from 150,000 (conservative floor) to

over 400,000 (SPR 2023 Expansion Study). At the low estimate, dogs outnumber children under 18 roughly 1.4 to 1.

Facilities per constituent: playgrounds for kids vs. OLAs for dogs



Source: TPL 2025 ParkScore Seattle (157 playgrounds) · OFM 2025 population · Seattle Humane / Cascade PBS dog population estimates (150K low bound)

OBSERVATION

The ratio of dedicated facilities to constituents is roughly 11× more favorable for children than for dogs (1 playground per ~733 kids vs. 1 OLA per ~10,700+ dogs using the low dog-population estimate).

FINDING 04

Acreage, not just count.

The four largest parks hold roughly 79% of total OLA acreage, and half of Seattle's OLAs are under one acre. The two smallest (Denny at 0.105 ac and Kinnear at 0.124 ac) are roughly a tenth of an acre each. Seven of 14 sit below the AKC 1-acre recommendation.

PART II • ACCESS

99% of Seattleites live within a 10-minute walk of a park. *Almost none of them* can legally use it with their dog.

11.7% of Seattleites are within a 10-minute walk of a legal off-leash area. 76.6% are within SPR's published 2.5-mile OLA standard. This chapter measures the gap between "a park" and "a park where dogs are legal."

10-MIN WALK TO ANY PARK

99%

Seattle residents, TPL 2025 ParkScore.

10-MIN NETWORK WALK TO AN OLA

11.7%

osmnx network + 2020 Census block groups.

SEATTLE'S DOG-PARK DENSITY

1.82

Per 100K residents — TPL 2025, below every West Coast peer.

OWNERS REPORTING ILLEGAL OFF-LEASH

39%

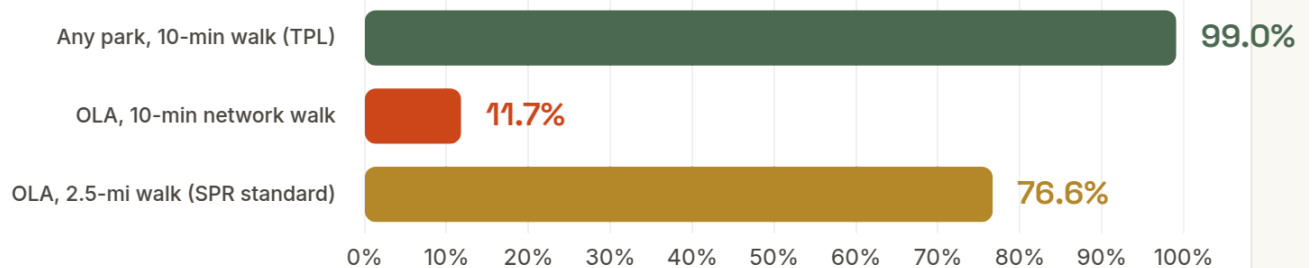
Monthly or more, SPR's 2016 survey.

Any park vs. a legally usable park.

Trust for Public Land's access metric uses a half-mile walkshed — the distance most people will walk before driving. By that measure, 99% of Seattle residents live within a 10-minute walk of a park. Applying the same metric to Seattle's off-leash areas produces a substantially smaller number.

Share of Seattle within a 10-minute walk

All three bars are population coverage. TPL's 99% for any park is their published figure. The two OLA bars are computed on this site: osmnx network walksheds around every OLA intersected with 2020 Census block-group population, area-weighted.



Source: TPL 2025 ParkScore Seattle (99%) · compute_walkshed.py (osmnx, Seattle OSM walk network) · population_coverage.py (2020 Census block groups) · data/walkshed/population_coverage.csv

OBSERVATION

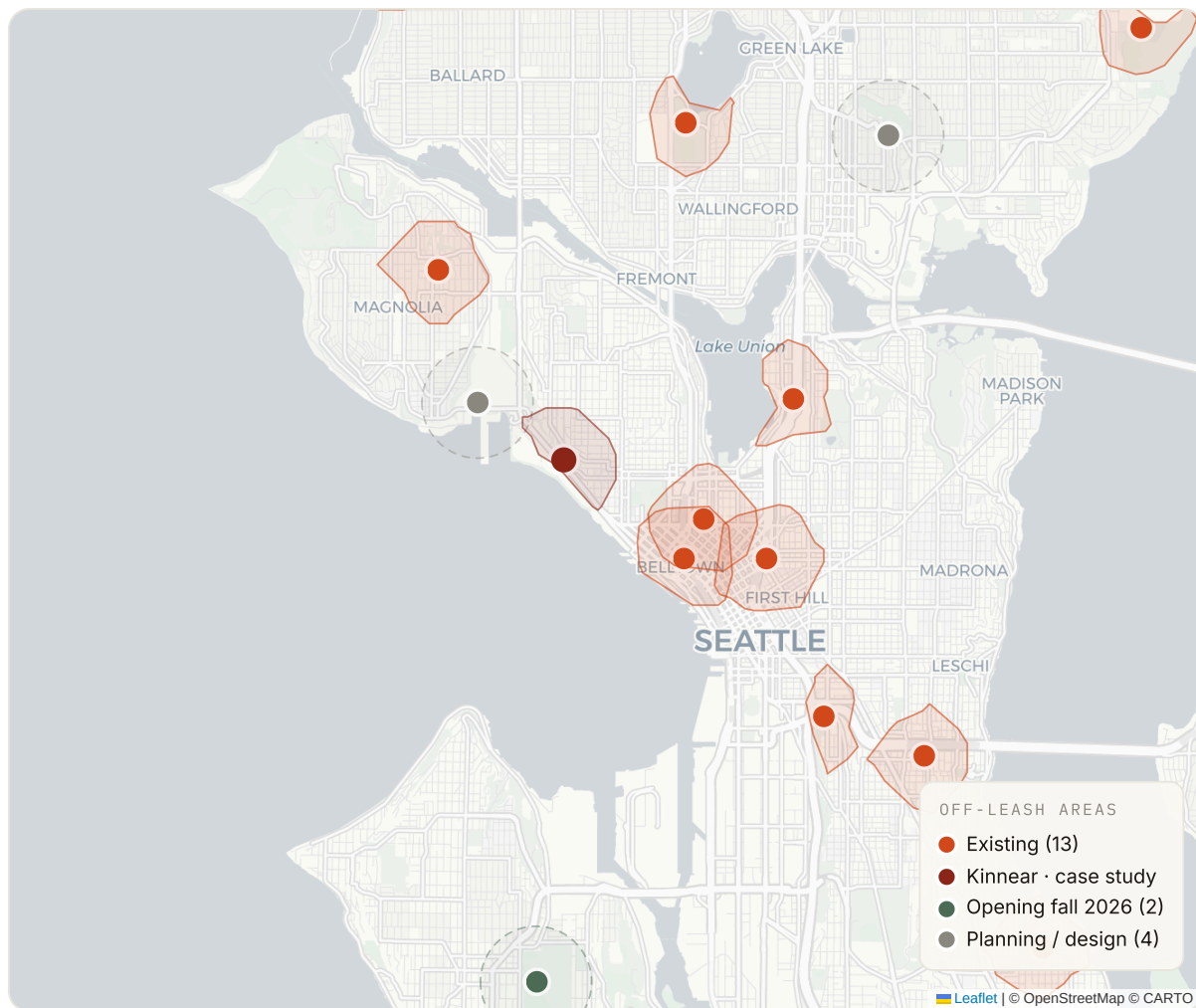
The 10-minute-walk standard yields 11.7% for OLAs. SPR's OLA-specific standard is 2.5 miles, which corresponds to roughly a 50-minute walk one way and covers 76.6% of residents. Applying the same 10-minute standard to both, 86,207 of Seattle's 737,559 residents (2020 Census) have a legal off-leash area within a 10-minute walk.

Mapping the OLA gap.

The map shows Seattle's 14 existing off-leash areas (half-mile network isochrones), the two under construction for fall 2026, and four in longer-term planning. Network walksheds follow the OSM pedestrian graph and stop at barriers — I-5, the Ship Canal, steep terrain — that a straight-line circle would cross.

Seattle off-leash areas, with half-mile walksheds

Half-mile network-distance isochrones along the OSM pedestrian graph. Planned and in-design sites shown as dashed straight-line half-mile circles.



Source: SPR OLA inventory · SPR Off-Leash Area Expansion Study (2023-24) · data/walkshed/ola_isochrones.geojson · tiles: CARTO / OpenStreetMap

OBSERVATION

Even after the two fall-2026 OLAs open and all four planned sites are built, coverage remains uneven. The southeast quadrant (Rainier Valley, Beacon Hill, Othello) gains access. Central and north neighborhoods (Ravenna, Wallingford, Green Lake, Phinney, Maple Leaf) remain largely uncovered. The nearest legal OLA for most of Queen Anne and Magnolia is Kinnear (0.124 acres).

FINDING 02B

Where citations happen vs. where walkshed reaches.

CITATIONS OUTSIDE ANY OLA 0.5-MI WALKSHED

72.2%

2,577 of the 3,570 placed citations (park-named + geocoded street addresses)

CITATIONS INSIDE AN OLA WALKSHED

27.8%

993 citations — concentrated at Magnuson (248), Lower Woodland (222), Golden Gardens (174), Genesee (130), Westcrest (86).

Of 35 uniquely identified parks in the citation data, **26 sit outside any OLA's 10-minute walkshed**. Nine sit inside; eight of those are themselves OLA host parks. At the larger host parks, citations are on the non-OLA portions (athletic fields, shorelines, wooded sections).

FINDING 03

How small is small?

The median Seattle OLA is under one acre. The two smallest (Denny at 0.105 ac and Kinnear at 0.124 ac) are roughly the footprint of a basketball court each. Portland's smallest fenced OLA is larger than Seattle's third-smallest.

AKC RECOMMENDATION

≥ 1 acre

Minimum size with 4–6 ft fence, per AKC Establishing a Dog Park in Your Community.

INDUSTRY DESIGN CONSENSUS

1–5 ac

Community dog-park sizing, with 1 acre as the practical floor (Parks & Rec Business; Ann Arbor; Fairfax County).

PER-DOG CAPACITY

75–100 sq ft

Recommended planning density at peak use. Below this, injury and behavioral-conflict risk rise.

Applied to Seattle's 14 OLAs: **seven of 14 are below the AKC 1-acre floor**. Three are below 0.25 acre. Implied peak capacity at the 100 sq ft per-dog standard, for the smallest sites:

OLA	AREA (SQ FT)	CAP AT 100 SF/DOG	CAP AT 75 SF/DOG	BELOW AKC 1-AC MIN?
Denny Park	4,574	46	61	Yes — 0.105 ac
Kinnear	5,401	54	72	Yes — 0.124 ac
Plymouth Pillars	8,712	87	116	Yes — 0.20 ac
Regrade	13,068	131	174	Yes — 0.30 ac
Magnolia Manor	20,909	209	279	Yes — 0.48 ac
I-5 Colonnade	21,780	218	290	Yes — 0.50 ac
Lower Woodland	32,670	327	436	Yes — 0.75 ac
Golden Gardens	43,560	436	581	At floor — 1.0 ac
Northacres	60,984	610	813	No — 1.4 ac
Blue Dog Pond	74,052	741	987	No — 1.7 ac
Genesee	117,612	1,176	1,568	No — 2.7 ac
Dr. Jose Rizal	174,240	1,742	2,323	No — 4.0 ac
Westcrest	365,904	3,659	4,879	No — 8.4 ac
Magnuson	392,040	3,920	5,227	No — 9.0 ac

OBSERVATION

Kinnear's implied peak capacity is 43 dogs at the 100 sq ft standard and 58 dogs at the 75 sq ft floor. SPR signage at the park asks owners with more than 3 dogs to use another OLA. Kinnear is the only designated OLA within a 10-minute walk of most of Queen Anne.

Factors associated with illegal off-leash use.

1. No legal option nearby.

About nine in ten Seattle residents are outside a 10-minute walk of an OLA (only 11.7% are within one). A 25-minute drive with a 70-pound dog is a higher friction cost than walking to the local park.

3. Site-adjacent safety concerns.

Several OLAs — among them Kinnear and Plymouth Pillars — sit adjacent to or are accessed through areas with chronic encampment and safety issues. The Kinnear case study below documents one 20-year record.

2. The legal option is small.

A 0.1-acre OLA (Kinnear, Denny) or 0.2-acre OLA (Regrade, Plymouth Pillars) has limited running room. Owners with high-energy dogs often choose a larger unauthorized space over a smaller authorized one.

Net pattern.

Enforcement data shows citations concentrated in neighborhoods without a nearby OLA, not distributed evenly across the city. The pattern is consistent with a supply-driven explanation.

CASE STUDY • 20-YEAR DOCUMENTED RECORD

Kinnear Park.

Queen Anne's only nearby OLA is Seattle's smallest at 0.124 acres. Located at the bottom of a hillside greenbelt on the southwest slope of Queen Anne Hill, it serves roughly 33,000 residents across Queen Anne and Magnolia.

A small OLA with long-running site-adjacent issues. Kinnear's OLA is at the far side of Lower Kinnear Park from the parking lot. Contemporaneous reporting and city records document a 20+-year pattern: 1999 & 2003 beating deaths reported in Lower Kinnear; 2000 Pro Parks Levy excludes Kinnear; 2007 a new dog run is approved (12th in the city) but noted encampment activity adjacent; 2011 closed briefly after a stabbing; 2012 opened after years of neighborhood advocacy; 2019 photographic record of tents pitched against OLA's back fence; 2025 KOMO coverage of ongoing encampment activity. The site's 20-year incident record is in `data/kinnear-timeline.csv`.

PART III • FORWARD

What works, and what Seattle *hasn't tried.*

Parts I and II document the supply and access gaps. Part III looks forward through three questions: which of Seattle's existing OLAs function well and why, what shared-use looks like in cities that have run it for decades, and what public land outside Seattle Parks' portfolio could host off-leash space without a new Park District dollar.

FINDING 03A

What works: three Seattle OLAs that draw sustained community support.

Magnuson — the volunteer-steward model

ACRES

9.0

Largest OLA in Seattle; only one with water access to Lake Washington.

OPENED

1996 / 1999

1996 pilot · 1999 permanent · former NAS Sand Point.

STEWARD

MOLG

All-volunteer 501(c)(3), founded 1999.

Magnuson is a structural outlier on land area, physical features (shoreline, gravel paths, woods), and governance. Magnuson Off-Leash Group (MOLG) is a 501(c)(3) nonprofit that raises donations, runs volunteer maintenance days, and partners formally with Seattle Parks. It is the closest parallel in Seattle to the Portland or San Francisco "dog park friends" model.

Sources: SPR Magnuson Off-Leash Area · MOLG (magnusondogpark.org) · HistoryLink June 15, 1996 trial opening

Genesee — the COLA-steward model

ACRES

2.7

Third-largest; small-dog area separated.

OPENED

2005

Genesee Park & Playfield, Columbia City.

STEWARD

COLA

Citizens for Off-Leash Areas, system-wide SPR partner since 1996.

COLA is the system-wide advocacy and stewardship group for Seattle's OLAs. COLA organized the 1996 resolution that created the year-long OLA pilot and the 1997 City Council vote that made OLAs permanent. Where MOLG is site-specific, COLA works across the whole system.

Westcrest — the recent-investment model

ACRES

8.4

Second-largest OLA; 2021–2022 renovation.

INVESTMENT

\$505K

Park District Major Maintenance & Asset Management Fund.

PARTNERS

HPAC + COLA

Highland Park Action Committee on-site.

Westcrest is an example of a funded OLA renovation. The 2021–2022 Park District renovation addressed drainage, erosion control, access/parking, and accessibility after seven months of closure, reopening June 10, 2022.

WHAT THE THREE PROFILES SHARE

Each has a named community partner, a specific governance structure, and enough physical area to absorb demand: Magnuson at 9.0 acres, Westcrest at 8.4, Genesee at 2.7 — compared to Kinnear at 0.124. The access story in Part II is about distance; the design story here is about size plus stewardship.

FINDING 03B

Shared-use: the off-leash-hours model in peer cities.

Several U.S. cities designate time-windowed off-leash access in existing parks rather than building new fenced OLAs. The policy has been in formal operation in New York City since 2007, and in functional operation for roughly two decades.

New York City — formal since 2007, functional longer

New York's current Dog Friendly Areas policy designates specific parks where dogs may be off-leash between 9pm and 9am. NYC Parks maintains the official list of Dog-Friendly Areas. Formalization happened in 2007 via a NYC Parks rulemaking action; the operational pattern predated formalization by a decade or more. Chicago and Boston run parallel variants; Chicago's Dog-Friendly Areas are closer to Seattle's fenced model, but Chicago allows specific park areas to operate on an off-leash basis during defined hours.

RELEVANCE TO SEATTLE

Seattle's 14 OLAs cover 11.7% of residents within a 10-minute walk. Time-windowed access to existing large parks — Green Lake, Volunteer Park, Lincoln Park, Seward Park, Discovery Park — would change the coverage figure without the multi-year capital timelines of building new dedicated OLAs.

FINDING 03C

Non-SPR land: public space SPR does not manage.

Seattle's OLA supply is bounded by SPR's real-estate portfolio. Significant acreage of other public land inside city limits — WSDOT right-of-way, Seattle City Light transmission corridors, Port of Seattle property — is, under current rules, unused for off-leash recreation. COLA raised this in its comments on SPR's 2023 Off-Leash Area Expansion Study: the study did not consider non-SPR public land.

WSDOT — state highway right-of-way

WSDOT manages land adjacent to every state-numbered road in the city. I-5 Colonnade — an existing Seattle OLA — sits under I-5 on WSDOT land, a functioning precedent.

Seattle City Light — transmission corridors

Seattle City Light owns transmission corridors running across the city. Several already host informal recreational use. These are typically fenced, signed, and maintained on a

predictable schedule — attributes compatible with off-leash use relative to most other non-Parks categories of public land.

Port of Seattle — waterfront and industrial-adjacent

The Port of Seattle owns substantial waterfront property. Most is industrial and security-restricted, but parcels at the edges — landscape buffer, parking, unused waterfront — may be compatible with off-leash use within the Port's operational constraints.

FRAMING OBSERVATION

Framed as "where can SPR build a new OLA on SPR land?" the answer is a multi-decade capital cycle. Framed as "where inside city limits is there public land where dogs could be off-leash without a new capital project?" the answer involves three agencies SPR has not historically partnered with on this use.

ENFORCEMENT

4,803 off-leash citations. *Where they happened*, and where they didn't.

Seattle Animal Control's records show the locations where dog owners were cited for illegal off-leash use between January 2014 and October 2019 (PRR C049204). Six of the top ten citation locations have no designated off-leash area.

CITATIONS ISSUED 2014-2019

4,803

SPR Animal Control, all offense levels.

TOP-10 HOTSPOTS WITH NO OLA

6

Of the 10 most-cited locations.

CITATIONS AT DISCOVERY PARK

420

Highest-cited single location; no OLA.

CITATIONS AT KINNEAR OLA

5

Queen Anne's only OLA (0.124 ac).

FINDING 01

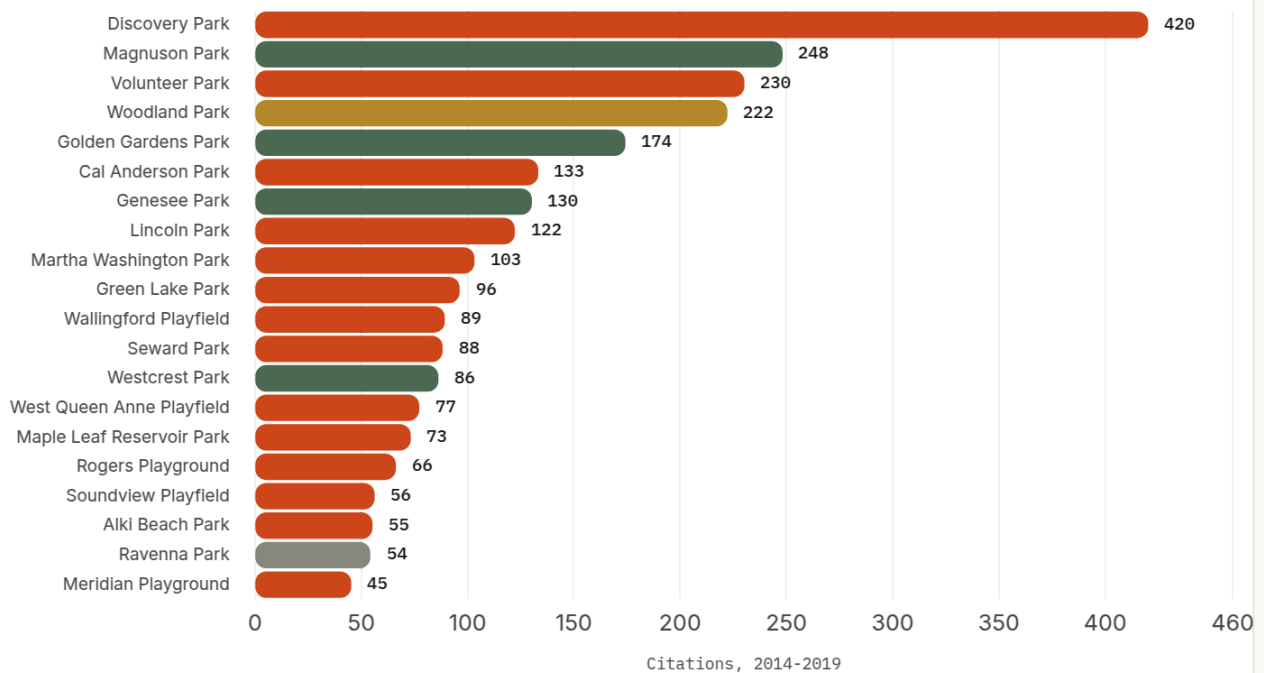
Top 20 locations by citation count.

Discovery Park alone accounts for about 9% of all citations in the dataset. The top four non-OLA parks (Discovery, Volunteer, Cal Anderson, Lincoln) account for 905

citations — roughly one in five.

Top 20 cited parks, 2014–2019

Orange bars = parks with no designated OLA. Sage bars = OLA host parks. Gold = partial OLA inside larger park. Grey = planned OLA.



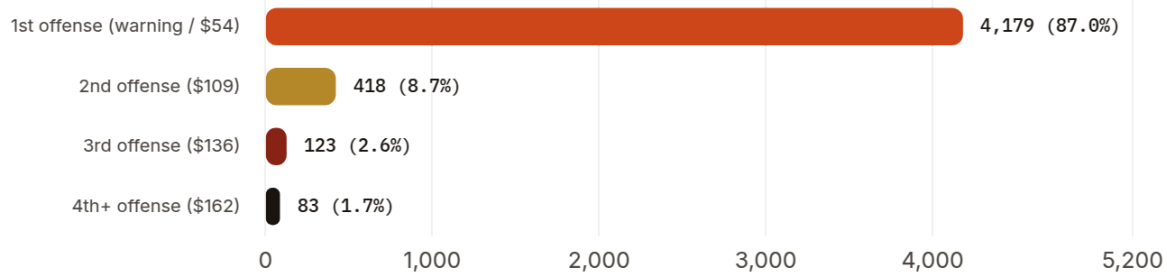
Source: SPR Animal Control PRR C049204 · park-name canonicalization in data/enforcement-by-park-year.csv

FINDING 02

Citation severity mix.

Seattle Municipal Code 18.12.080(A) escalates citations by offense count — 1st offense is warning or \$54 fine; 2nd is \$109; 3rd is \$136; 4th and beyond is \$162. The majority are first offenses.

Citations by offense level, 2014–2019



Source: SPR Animal Control PRR C049204 • SMC 18.12.080(A)

OBSERVATION

Roughly 87% of citations are first offenses; 2nd, 3rd, and 4th-plus offenses together are about 13%. The distribution is consistent with a broad population of occasional violators rather than a concentrated set of repeat offenders.

FINDING 03

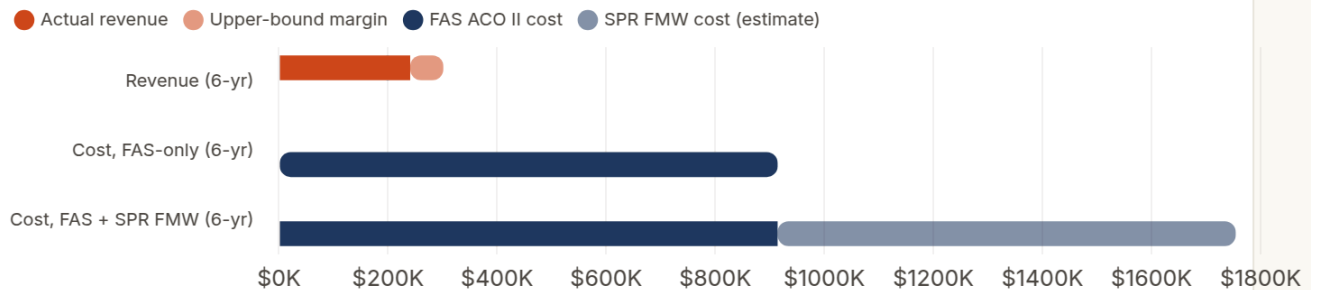
Revenue vs. enforcement program cost.

Using the signed 2021 MOA's disclosed FAS-side cost of one ACO II (\$152,399/year) and the per-tier fees recorded in the citations CSV, fee revenue covers a fraction of the program's direct personnel cost.

Citation fee revenue vs. enforcement program cost

Actual revenue: sum of the fee column in the enforcement citations dataset (\$240,652 across 2014–2019). Lighter band: upper bound if every row had been billed at max fee for its tier.

Program cost uses 2021 MOA ACO II line (\$152,399/year, FAS-only) for the six-year period.



Source: revenue computed from data/enforcement-citations.csv (per-tier fees from SMC 18.12.080) · cost from SPR/FAS 2021 MOA Attachment A

OBSERVATION

Across the six-year PRR window, the program generated roughly \$241,000 in assessed fee revenue against roughly \$915,000 in FAS-side ACO salary and divisional overhead. Including the paired SPR-side Facilities Maintenance Worker (the 2021 MOA treats ACO + FMW as a team) brings the cost estimate to about \$1.76M, taking cost recovery to roughly 14%. The off-leash enforcement program is not self-funding at any of the fee tiers currently in place.

BUDGET

The SPR budget, and the *off-leash* share of it.

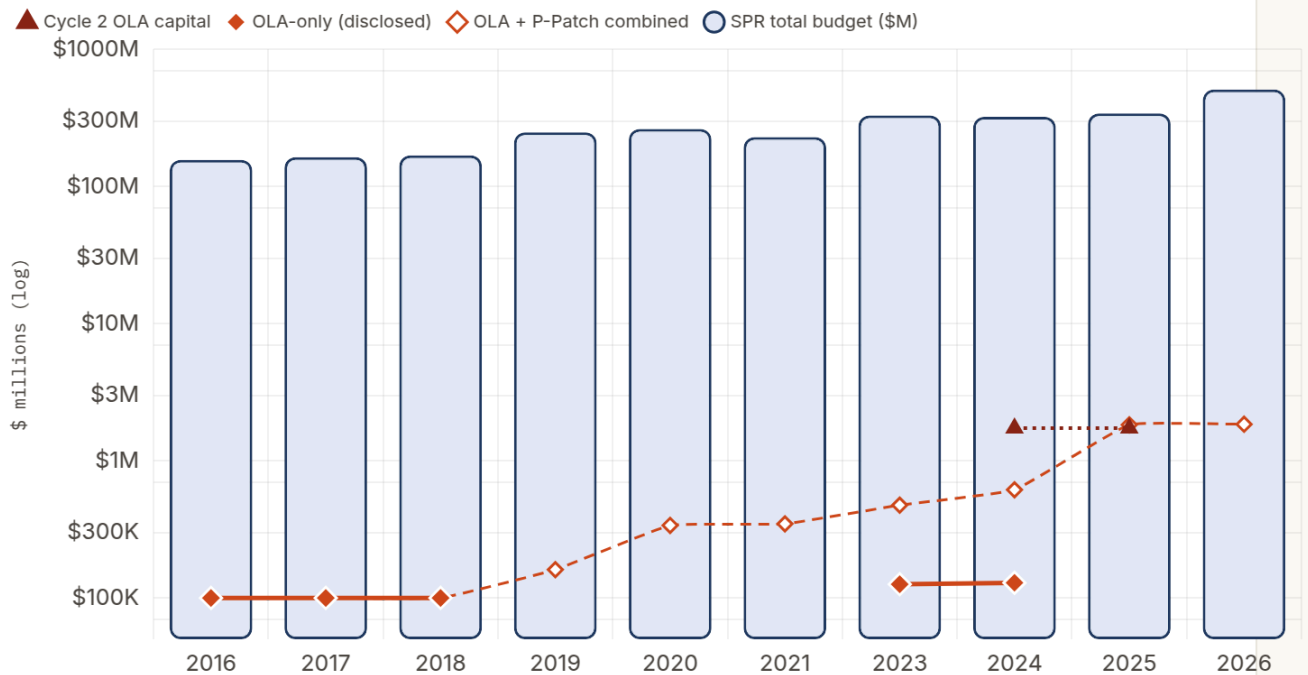
SPR's total budget has roughly tripled since 2018 to \$507M proposed. The disclosed dedicated-OLA line peaked at 0.064% of SPR's total in 2016 (\$100K of \$156M), slipped to 0.06% by 2018, and the OLA-only split has not been separately published since.

FINDING 01

SPR total budget vs. OLA-related spending, 2016–2026.

SPR total budget vs. OLA-related budget line, 2016–2026

All values in millions on a single log-scale axis. Solid orange diamonds mark years where SPR publicly disclosed the OLA-only amount. Hollow dashed line shows the combined OLA + P-Patch community-garden line — the OLA share is smaller by an unknown amount.

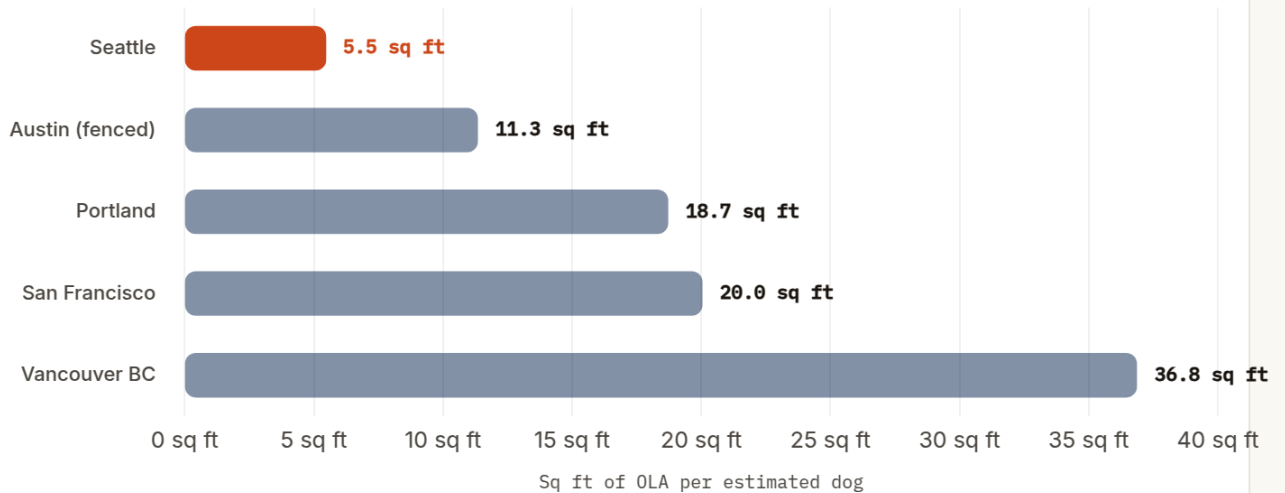


Source: Seattle City Budget Office archives · Parkways (SPR blog) · Seattle Park District Cycle 1 & Cycle 2 financial plans · [data/budget-detail.csv](#)

Off-leash space per dog, peer cities.

Off-leash space per dog, five West Coast & peer cities

Dogs estimated at 30% of population. Methodology differs across cities; each bar carries its caveat in the tooltip.



Source: SPR OLA inventory · Portland PP&R, SF Rec & Parks, Vancouver Park Board, Austin PARD · data/peer-cities.csv

FINDING 03

The raw budget table.

YEAR	CYCLE	SPR TOTAL (\$M)	OLA+P - PATCH (\$K)	OLA - ONLY (\$K)	CAPITAL (\$K)	OLA % OF SPR
2016	Cycle 1	\$156	\$100	\$100	—	0.064%
2017	Cycle 1	\$163	\$100	\$100	—	0.061%
2018	Cycle 1	\$168	\$100	\$100	—	0.060%
2019	Cycle 1	\$247.7	\$160.8	not disclosed	—	—
2020	Cycle 1	\$261.9	\$338.0	not disclosed	—	—
2021	Cycle 1	\$228.1	\$346.7	not disclosed	—	—
2023	Cycle 2	\$328.2	\$475.1	\$126	—	0.038%
2024	Cycle 2	\$320.7	\$614.3	\$129	\$1,730	0.040% + capital
2025	Cycle 2	\$339.4	\$1,829.7	not disclosed	\$1,730	—
2026	Cycle 2	\$506.9	\$1,845.7	not disclosed	—	—

OLA-only line. Cycle 1 \$100K/year OLA-only is from SPR's own 2016 public statement. Cycle 2 \$126K (2023) and \$129K (2024) are from Parkways coverage. Post-2024 OLA-only splits are not publicly disclosed; the Maintaining Parks & Facilities BSL (BC-PR-50000) is reported as a combined OLA + P-Patch number. **Combined OLA + P-Patch.** The post-2019 line values include both OLA maintenance and P-Patch community-garden maintenance. The 2023 and 2024 disclosed OLA-only portions are roughly 21–26% of the combined BSL, suggesting P-Patch is the larger share. **One-time capital.** Cycle 2 includes \$3.46M across 2024–2026 for W. Seattle Stadium OLA, Othello Playground OLA, and Ravenna design.

PEER CITIES

How eight peer cities *run* their off-leash systems.

Per-city detail on Portland, San Francisco, Vancouver BC, Washington DC, Minneapolis, New York, Austin, and Boise. Counting methodology, governance, funding, operating rules, and at least one design choice per city that Seattle has not used.

METHODOLOGY CAVEAT

Peer-city OLA counts use different definitions. Seattle counts only fully-fenced dedicated OLAs; Portland includes unfenced voice-control; Vancouver BC includes time-restricted beach and field access; SF mixes fenced and voice-control; Austin's headline figure is inflated by large natural-area voice-control sites.

PEER 01

Portland, OR — the voice-control model

Portland Parks & Recreation operates a mix of fenced and unfenced off-leash sites, with unfenced voice-control areas making up the majority. The city's own page describes "over 30 dog off-leash areas — both fenced and unfenced," which is the fundamental methodological difference from Seattle's fenced-only count. Portland's per-capita rate is 3.2× Seattle's, using each city's own published count. Funding: PP&R general fund plus the voter-approved Parks Local Option Levy (~\$47M/yr citywide, renewed November 2020). Portland uses the general half-mile / 10-minute walk standard; there is no OLA-specific walkshed standard.

PEER 02

San Francisco, CA — 36 DPAs inside a federal-lands dispute

SF Rec & Park operates 36 designated Dog Play Areas (DPAs), a mix of fully fenced and voice-control zones within larger parks. Golden Gate Park alone contains four DPAs. Capital via voter GO bonds: Prop A 2000, Prop B 2012 (\$195M), and Prop B 2020 (\$487M Health & Recovery Bond). SF has no mandatory dog license, so license revenue does not fund parks. SF's defining complication is the GGNRA Dog Management Plan — the federal-lands restriction on off-leash access that Seattle does not have.

PEER 03

Vancouver, BC — the elected Park Board

Vancouver's Park Board is the only independently-elected parks body in any major Canadian city — seven commissioners elected by voters, running parks independently of City Council. The 2017 People, Parks, and Dogs strategy is the most detailed OLA planning framework among the eight peer cities. Recent builds (2023–2026): Heather Park OLA (opened 2025), Granville Park OLA, Emery Barnes Park OLA renewal, Cooper's Park OLA renewal — approximately \$2.1M in OLA-specific capital across the four-year cycle. Vancouver uses seasonal time-restricted beach access (Spanish Banks, Sunset Beach, Kits Beach) — a reference point for Seattle's shared-use framing.

PEER 04

Washington, DC — the only peer with an OLA-specific statute

DC operates 16 designated dog parks across all eight wards, all fully fenced. DC is the only peer with an OLA-specific enabling statute: the 2005 Dog Park Establishment Act (DC Law 16-175) defines what a Dog Park Area is, requires fencing, requires a recognized "Friends of" group to sign an MOU for stewardship, and requires DOEE environmental sign-off per site. Seattle's OLAs exist under a 1997 Parks ordinance without statutory-level definition, without a required stewardship structure, and without required per-site environmental review.

PEER 05

Minneapolis, MN — the permit-fee model

The Minneapolis Park & Recreation Board (MPRB) operates nine off-leash dog parks, and is the only major US peer that treats OLAs as a user-pays service. Every dog using any of the nine OLAs must carry an annual permit (\$38 Minneapolis resident, first dog; \$66 non-resident; \$5 daily). Permit revenue funds the Off-Leash Dog Park Enterprise Fund. Like Vancouver, MPRB is an independently-elected park body — a separate taxing district with its own Board of Commissioners, outside City Council jurisdiction.

PEER 06

New York City — the shared-use hours model

NYC operates both dedicated fenced dog runs and a city-wide Off-Leash Hours policy formally codified on May 10, 2007 (informally since ~1986). In designated areas of participating parks, licensed and vaccinated dogs may be off-leash from park-opening until 9 AM and from 9 PM until park-close. The designated footprint spans dozens of parks across all five boroughs; Central Park alone has 23 dog-friendly zones. Nineteen years of formal operation across multiple administrations, no reversal. NRPA's November 2018 Parks & Recreation law review treats the NYC model as the mature US example.

PEER 07

Austin, TX — the acreage-headline caveat

Austin is cited in several "most dog-friendly cities" rankings for its large off-leash acreage (~682 acres). That figure is not apples-to-apples: Austin counts large natural-area parks with voice-control designation rather than fenced dedicated OLAs. The fenced-OLA comparable is closer to ~80 acres, one-eighth of the headline. On dog-parks-per-100K (TPL), Austin's 1.28 is below Seattle's 1.82.

Boise, ID — layered access in a smaller city

Boise has roughly a third of Seattle's population (240K) and more than four times the dog parks per capita using each city's own published count. Boise's off-leash system has two layers Seattle does not: seven fenced permanent sites plus eleven additional parks with designated off-leash hours. The seasonal program (Ann Morrison Park, Optimist and Simplot Sports Complexes) allows dogs off-leash during winter months when sports fields are inactive. The two-layer model (permanent fenced plus time-windowed shared-use) is the design choice Seattle has not used.

CROSS-PEER PATTERN

Seven of the eight peer cities operate at least one form of shared-use, time-zoned, or voice-control access alongside fenced dedicated OLAs. Seattle's all-fenced, single-designation model is the outlier in this set of cities. No peer publishes a dog-park-specific walkshed standard; every peer uses the same 10-minute / half-mile standard that TPL, NRPA, ULI, NPS, and CDC use for parks generally. SPR's 2.5-mile OLA-specific standard is 5× the distance used by peer cities for parks overall.

THIS IS THE OPINION PAGE

Every other chapter in this report is factual. This one is signed editorial — principles, opinions, counterarguments, and a policy recommendation from the site's author. Data claims link back to the factual chapters.

OPINION · SIGNED EDITORIAL · APRIL 2026

Seattle will not build its way out of this. *It needs a policy change.*

This is my take on what the data in this report shows, and what the city should do differently.

BY **ANDRE VRIGNAUD**, QUEEN ANNE · 20+ YEARS USING SEATTLE'S PARKS WITH DOGS · PARTICIPATED IN SPR'S 2014-2017 PEOPLE, DOGS AND PARKS LIVE INTERVIEWS.

I'll be upfront — I own dogs, I walk them in Seattle's parks, I run them off-leash, and I have a strong opinion about how the city has managed off-leash access. The rest of this report is deliberately neutral. This chapter isn't. What follows is six principles, three opinions that fall out of the data, seven counterarguments I've tried to take seriously, and a recommendation I've been sharing with the city since 2014.

The broader argument: *this is a hard problem.*

One thing first, because it gets lost in advocacy writing on this topic — this is a hard problem. Park space in a dense, land-scarce city is finite, and the people asking for more of it all have legitimate claims — dog owners, soccer leagues, community gardeners, neighbors who want a quiet lawn to read on, kids who want a playground, runners, cyclists, birders. Every one of them can point to data saying they're under-served. Several of them are right at the same time.

Not everyone leaves happy. Any real change here upsets someone. A policy that gives dogs more access feels like a loss to people who'd rather be in parks without them. A policy that protects the status quo leaves 150,000+ dogs and their owners exactly where the rest of this report documents.

PULL QUOTE

At some point, continuing to run a strategy that measurably isn't working becomes its own choice.

Part One: six principles

P1 Seattle will never build its way out of the OLA shortage.

Zero net dog parks added since 2009 — seventeen years and counting — while the population grew 34%. Two more open in fall 2026. Even if SPR eventually builds every site on its current list, the per-capita gap to Portland, San Francisco, and Vancouver BC doesn't close. Seattle is physically constrained: dense, land-scarce, expensive parcels, already-extensive parks to maintain.

P2 The little buildable land Seattle has should not go to dog parks first.

Seattle's in the middle of a long housing-affordability crisis and an ongoing homelessness emergency. When a rare parcel of city land comes loose, the case for housing, shelter, or services is stronger than the case for a new fenced dog park. I own dogs and I still believe this.

P3 Seattle has more dogs than children, and the investment gap reflects that poorly.

The obvious part first — **yes, kids should be prioritized over dogs**. A city with 157 playgrounds and 14 dog parks is making a choice about who its parks are for, and on the first axis that choice is right. What I'm arguing is that the *magnitude* of the gap has gone past any reasonable prioritization. The dedicated OLA budget line in 2018 was about **\$100,000 out of a \$168M SPR total**: roughly **0.06%**. Prioritizing kids is right. Arriving at 0.06% for a population the size of all dog owners is how we got here.

P4 People who don't want to be around dogs have a right not to be.

Non-negotiable. Every dog owner I respect accepts this. Kids who are afraid of dogs, adults who don't want a strange dog in their face, picnickers, joggers — none of them signed up to share space with an unfamiliar off-leash dog. The current setup, where 39% of dog owners self-report monthly-or-more illegal off-leash use, fails these residents directly.

P5 Children have a right to play on clean, safe fields.

A playfield with dog feces on it, or a baseball diamond where someone's loose dog just ran through left field, is a system failure on every axis. This isn't a dog-vs-kid argument — both groups deserve protected recreational space. The current policy doesn't actually deliver clean playfields; enforcement happens at the margins, after the fact, with no cleanup component.

P6 Families and non-dog-owners should have park time that's reliably dog-free.

Access goes both ways. Right now, dog owners have a few tiny, often-unsafe OLAs; non-owners have a city full of parks that are technically dog-free but in practice aren't. Both groups lose. A well-designed policy protects time windows for each use.

Part Two: three opinions that fall out of the data

01 The current rules have failed, and Seattle is doubling down on the part that isn't working.

In 2014 the Seattle City Council asked SPR to rethink off-leash policy. SPR spent over a year running surveys and in-person interviews. The consistent feedback was that the pre-2014 policy was unworkable, enforcement was structurally insufficient, and other cities had already tried shared-use or time-zoned models worth studying. The resulting People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan kept the same framework, added two full-time animal-control officers, and declined to pilot any shared-use approach. In April 2026, Axios Seattle reported that SPR is expanding enforcement again — from one officer Wed-Sat to two full-time seven-day positions plus backup. That's the same lever, pulled harder.

02 Fines will never work — not at any amount Seattle could plausibly adopt.

4,803 off-leash citations between January 2014 and October 2019, against a dog population of at least 150,000. Roughly 0.5% chance per dog per year of being cited. About 90% of citations were first-offense warnings at \$0 or \$54. Second offense is \$109, third is \$136, fourth-plus is \$162. The practical ceiling is about \$162, and even the SMC's \$150 maximum gets absorbed by higher-income owners as a de-facto access fee. Raise fines higher and you hit a regressive-enforcement problem. The fine-based model is structurally mismatched to the behavior.

03 Dog owners will keep running dogs off-leash under the current rules. For rational reasons.

People break the law here because the legal option is often worse. Many neighborhoods have no legal OLA within a 10-minute walk. Where a legal OLA exists, it's often too small to use safely — seven of Seattle's 14 are under one acre. Several OLAs sit in or next to areas with chronic safety concerns that make them effectively unusable — especially for women, after dark, or alone. And the probability of enforcement is under 1% per year. It's a supply failure producing a compliance failure.

PULL QUOTE

It's a supply failure producing a compliance failure, exactly what basic economics would predict.

Part Three: counterarguments

Before I get to the recommendation, the best arguments against it. Every one below was made by a real neighbor in a 147-comment April 2021 Nextdoor thread. Where the counterargument is correct, I say so.

C1 "Dogs are not allowed on this playfield. The rules are clear."

This is correct. SMC 18.12.080 is unambiguous. My argument isn't that individual rule-breaking is justified — it's that the rule has failed at the *system* level, and the system needs policy change.

C2 "Having a dog is a privilege, not a right."

Agreed in the narrow sense — and I think it's the wrong frame. Dog ownership is discretionary. It's also mainstream. When a city allocates 0.06% of its parks budget to a constituency of roughly 25% of residents, the question isn't whether dog ownership is a "right." It's whether the allocation matches the constituency. It doesn't.

C3 "Off-leash dogs cause real harm to other park users."

Confirmed. The current setup produces these incidents *despite* the law, because enforcement is structurally insufficient. A time-zoned model with dedicated cleanup staff directly addresses this by reserving prime athletic hours for athletic use.

C4 "The dogs-to-children ratio isn't a reasonable basis for OLA budget."

Correct. "More dogs than children" is a scale indicator, not a prescription. What I'm arguing is narrower: SPR's 0.06% allocation for a population that's 25%+ of residents is an order-of-magnitude mismatch.

C5 "There's no land. If there were, it should go to housing first."

Yes, and yes. That's exactly why my recommendation isn't "build a lot more OLAs." It's a time-zoned shared-use policy on parks the city already owns.

C6 "Don't take it out on people using the playfield. Lobby for change."

Fair. A parent watching softball practice didn't personally set SPR's OLA allocation. My argument here is only with the city. People *have* lobbied. COLA has lobbied. The QACC Parks Chair has spent two decades lobbying. At some point "lobby harder" stops being a serious response.

C7 "Don't fantasize a shared-use pilot will be enforced better."

Fair and concrete. A time-bounded window is something an owner can plan around, which the current blanket rule isn't. You can't enforce every park every minute of every day. You *can* enforce a handful of designated parks at two specific transition points per day. That's what New York has done for 20+ years.

Part Four: SPR's own access standard proves the point

SPR's 2017 People, Dogs and Parks Strategic Plan defends current OLA coverage by claiming most residents live within **2.5 miles** of an OLA. The Green Lake loop is 2.8 miles. SPR is effectively arguing that walking the Green Lake loop one-way to reach your dog park counts as reasonable access. The industry-standard metric — used by TPL, NRPA, ULI, NPS, and CDC — is **0.5 miles**. SPR uses the tighter standard when it's celebrating Seattle's park system in general, and a standard 5× more permissive to paper over the OLA-specific failure. That asymmetry alone is the argument.

Part Five: what Seattle should actually do

THE RECOMMENDATION

A time-zoned shared-use policy for Seattle's parks.

Adopt a shared-use model similar to New York City's long-standing off-leash hours policy — early morning and evening windows in designated parks during which dogs may be off-leash under owner control, with the rest of the day reserved for traditional park use. Pair it with a different enforcement posture focused on shared-use compliance, not leash-law violations.

1. **Designate shared-use parks by neighborhood.** Not every park participates. Parks with heavy children's programming stay fully leashed 24/7. Parks that show up in enforcement data as places people off-leash anyway become eligible candidates.
2. **Time-zone the access.** A model like NYC's — off-leash from park-opening to 9:00 AM and from 9:00 PM to park-closing — gives owners practical morning and evening windows and reserves prime daytime hours for general park use. Pilot it. Adjust hours per park based on observed use.
3. **Pivot enforcement from fines to compliance.** Redeploy SPR Animal Control and park rangers to monitor participating parks during off-leash hours — confirming owners are present, dogs are under control, and the park is left clean.
4. **Add clean-park staffing — call it poop patrol.** A dedicated crew does post-session sweeps at the transition back to leashed hours. If a participating park is repeatedly found uncleaned, it can lose shared-use designation. That collective threat is the real enforcement mechanism.
5. **Fund it with expanded dog-license fees and redirected enforcement spend.** A meaningful license-fee increase, dedicated to the Seattle Animal Shelter and the clean-park program, is far more politically viable than a fines increase.
6. **Keep the small dedicated OLAs.** Kinnear, Plymouth Pillars, Magnuson, and the rest don't go away. They stay as all-day off-leash options. They just stop being the *entire* answer to a city-wide demand they were never sized to handle.
7. **Measure and publish outcomes.** Track citation counts, Find-It-Fix-It complaints, injury reports, and post-session cleanliness audits by park. If a pilot park is underperforming, pull it. If it's working, expand.

This approach was raised during the 2014–2017 SPR process, was supported by COLA and multiple community members, and was set aside as too hard to enforce. The data in this report suggests the current approach is *also* too hard to enforce — 4,803 citations over six years against 150,000+ dogs. If we're going to have a policy that's difficult to enforce either way, we should pick the one that could actually work if we did.

Part Six: what I'd ask of the City Council and the Mayor

Before the next study begins, the Council should put on the record that the 2023–24 Expansion Study returned an almost identical plan to the 2017 strategic plan, that the plan has measurably failed to close the gap at both junctures, and that returning a third time with the same framework is not an acceptable deliverable.

The charge to SPR — or to whichever body runs the next study — should explicitly require the production of at least one genuine alternative. A shared-use time-zoned pilot is one such idea. It's not the only one. Which specific alternative lands on the table matters less than that at least one does. A third round built on the same two levers — *build a few more OLAs, fine the off-leash violators* — is not an acceptable deliverable.

The Council has the standing here that individual advocates and SPR itself don't. SPR works with the mandate it's given. If the mandate keeps asking for a version of the same answer, it will keep getting a version of the same answer. Making "same plan, different cover page" an unacceptable outcome is the one thing only the Council can do.

— *Andre Vrignaud*

QUEEN ANNE, SEATTLE · APRIL 2026

Methodology & *caveats*.

This site favors explicit methodology over headline-friendly numbers. The master reference is **METHODOLOGY.md** in the repo. A few caveats to carry:

- **Walkshed (network-based).** 11.7% of Seattle residents live within a 10-minute walking path of an OLA, computed via `scripts/compute_walkshed.py` (osmnx against Seattle's OSM walk network, 110,383 nodes / 305,582 edges) and `scripts/population_coverage.py` (2020 Census block-group overlay, area-weighted). SPR's published 2.5-mile standard covers 76.6%.
- **Peer-city OLA counts differ in definition.** Seattle counts only fully-fenced dedicated OLAs; Portland includes unfenced voice-control; Vancouver BC includes time-restricted shared-use. Direct comparison requires caveats.
- **OLA-specific budget.** SPR's Park District "Maintaining Parks & Facilities" line funds both OLAs and P-Patch community gardens and is not broken out. The \$100K/year Cycle 1 figure is OLA-only; Cycle 2 figures are combined.
- **Dog population.** Triangulated from three sources: ~26,700 active dog licenses (Seattle Open Data hard floor), an AVMA-derived demographic estimate of ~248,900, and SPR 2023 Expansion Study range of 187K–400K. The report uses 150,000 as a conservative floor for per-dog math.
- **Enforcement PRR window.** Citation data covers January 1, 2014 through October 15, 2019 (PRR C049204). A follow-up PRR for October 2019 onward has been filed.

Primary *data*.

All underlying data lives in the GitHub repo at

github.com/avrignaud/seattledogparkdata/tree/main/data. Plain CSVs; no database, no build step, no login required. Key files: `seattle-olas.csv` (14 OLAs); `seattle-timeseries.csv` (population / budget / OLA count 2010–2026); `peer-cities.csv`; `planned-olas.csv`; `kinnear-timeline.csv`; `enforcement-citations.csv` (PRR C049204); `walkshed/ola_isochrones.geojson`; `SOURCES.md`.

AI DISCLOSURE

This site was built by Claude, Anthropic's AI assistant. The underlying data — public records requests, SPR budget documents, census data, peer-city research — was collected by the author. The author reviewed the output before publication. The Opinion chapter reflects his personal views.

CORRECTIONS AND CONTRIBUTIONS WELCOME

If you find an error — a wrong number, a stale figure, a methodological flaw, or a better primary source — file an issue at

[GITHUB.COM/AVRIGNAUD/SEATTLEDOGPARKDATA/ISSUES](https://github.com/avrignaud/seattledogparkdata/issues)

(preferred — corrections stay public and auditable) or email

SEATTLEDOGPARKDATA@OZYMANDI.AS

. Known gaps where outside help would be especially useful: current dog-population estimates, per-OLA usage data, SPR's internal budget split between OLAs and P-Patches, and off-leash enforcement records after October 2019.

Source code and all data: github.com/avrignaud/seattledogparkdata · MIT license covers author-written code and analysis. Primary data (SPR public records, Seattle Open Data, U.S. Census) is all public record. TPL ParkServe data is redistributed under TPL's own terms of use. The canonical, always-current version of this report lives at seattledogparkdata.com.

— *seattledogparkdata.com*

A PUBLIC DATA REFERENCE · APRIL 2026 · ANDRE VRIGNAUD, QUEEN ANNE